also provided a vital route for Iraq's imports and exports through the port of Aqaba. This was essential for Iraq when its access to the Gulf was cut off by Iranian forces.

Syria, however, supported Iran because of intense rivalry with its neighbour, Iraq. The Syrians shut the Iraqi pipelines which passed through its territory to the Mediterranean. In return, Syria received free Iranian oil.

The USA was always more supportive of the Iraqis, as were France, Germany and the Soviet Union. They were all bitterly opposed to the new regime in Iran. The Soviet Union and France became the main suppliers of arms to Iraq. America's support became more active when the Iranians counterattacked and talked of advancing on Baghdad. The thought of the revolutionary Iranians controlling so much of the oil in the Gulf terrified the Americans as well as most of the Arab states. Khomeini might then be able to control world oil prices! And an Iranian victory might lead to the collapse of pro-Western regimes in the Gulf. Using their satellite technology, the Americans kept Iraq informed of Iranian troop movements. They also provided Iraq with equipment which was later used to make chemical weapons and, like the Arab states, they turned a blind eye when these were used against the Iranians.

Much of the war was focused on the Gulf, the vital route through which both Iraq and Iran exported their oil. The Iraqi air force controlled the skies but the Iranian navy was stronger. When the Iranians cut off Iraq's access to the Gulf through the Shatt al-Arab waterway, the USA provided protection for Iraqi shipping and destroyed much of the Iranian navy.

Key question
What were the results of the war?

The end of the war 1988

The Iranians finally accepted a ceasefire in 1988. Their economy was in ruins, the stream of 'martyrs' had subsided and they faced the prospect of a direct war with the USA. There was no peace treaty, only a truce, and both sides continued to re-arm. No one knows the exact figure of war dead but it is estimated that nearly a million Iranians and half a million Iraqis had died in the eight years of war. Although there had been a stalemate between the two sides for much of the war, there had been massive rocket attacks, by both sides, in the 'war of the cities' which led to huge civilian casualties and massive destruction. Brutality, on a huge scale, had been carried out by both sides. It had been one of the longest and most destructive wars since the Second World War.

Both sides had hoped that minority ethnic groups within the enemy country would rise up and welcome the invaders. The Iraqis had hoped that the Arab Sunni Muslims in the Khuzestan region of south-west Iran (see the map on page 122) would rise up and welcome their fellow Arab Sunnis from Iraq as liberators but that did not happen. Nor did the Shiites of southern Iraq join the advancing Shiite forces of Iran when they crossed the border into Iraq. National feelings (and loyalty to their rulers) proved stronger in both cases. No doubt terror played a part too: they